Architecture Decision Record

Record an important technical decision: its context, the options you considered, what you chose, and the trade-offs.

Manage Flow · Inspired by Michael Nygard's ADR Format · Decisions Worth Remembering

WORKED EXAMPLE · FICTIONAL TEAM

ADR NUMBER: ADR 007

DATE: 8 May

1 Title & Status

ONE DECISION PER RECORD

Title (short, e.g. “Use event queues for order updates”): Read stock levels from a read-only replica for substitutes

Deciders: Sam, Warehouse lead, Platform

Status: ☐ Proposed ☑ Accepted ☐ Rejected ☐ Deprecated ☐ Superseded by ADR # _____

2 Context

WHAT FORCES ARE AT PLAY?

The problem, the constraints, and why a decision is needed now

Substitutes need live stock levels to suggest a swap.

The Warehouse team's Stock API is two weeks late, and may slip again.

Substitutes are our next Sprint Goal, and the campaign date is fixed (30 June).

Warehouse already runs a read-only replica of the stock database for reporting.

We need a decision before Sprint 19 planning on 12 May.

3 Decision Drivers

WHAT MATTERS MOST

e.g. cost, performance, team skills, time to market, security, reversibility

- ☑ Ship substitutes before the campaign
- ☑ No extra load on the warehouse system
- ☑ Easy to switch to the Stock API later
- ☐ Data no more than 5 minutes old
- ☑ Customer data stays in the UK and EU
- ☐

4 Options Considered

AT LEAST TWO, INCLUDING “DO NOTHING”

OPTION	PROS	CONS	EFFORT / COST	CHOSEN?
Do nothing: wait for the API	no extra work; one clean interface	substitutes slip past the campaign	none	no
Read from the replica	unblocks us now; warehouse unaffected	up to 5 min stale; a second path	S: 3 days	yes ✓
Copy stock data nightly	simple; no live dependency	a day stale: bad swaps	M: 1 week	no

5 Decision

We will... read stock levels from the replica behind one small adapter,

and switch the adapter to the Stock API when it ships.

6 Consequences

WHAT BECOMES EASIER, AND HARDER

Easier / good

substitutes can ship in Sprint 19

one place to change later

Harder / trade-offs

swaps may use 5-minute-old stock

replica access to keep secure

“Will someone joining next year understand why we did this?”

“What would make us revisit this decision?”

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